

Goals, Planning, Tracking

IT Product Development

Innopolis University, 2026

Agenda

- Discussion questions
- Goals
- Threshold of success
- Strategic planning
- Tactical planning

Goals

Discussion questions

What is a goal?

What are properties of unambiguous goals?

How to communicate goals to other people?

SMART goals

A goal is an idea of the future or desired result that people envision, plan, and commit to achieve.“ - [Goal on Wiki](#)

The **SMART** goal format lets you state goals precisely so that others can agree on what success wrt. this goal is and later tell whether it was achieved.

SMART goal:

- **Specific**: what exactly will be done, and for whom?
- **Measurable**: what evidence or number proves it is done?
- **Achievable**: can we reach it with our skills, time, and resources?
- **Relevant**: does it serve the project's threshold of success?
- **Time-bound**: by when, with a date?

SMART goal example

Example

By the Week 3 soft deadline, October 15, 2026, our team ships a minimum usable product in which a user completes the core task chosen in Week 2 end to end, and the customer accepts it at that week's meeting.

Properties

- **Specific** — the MUP vertical slice for the core task, built only from Must Have stories.
- **Measurable** — the core task runs end to end, and the customer's verdict is recorded as a DEC-*nnn*.
- **Achievable** — one course week, a 3–4 person team, using a candidate already reviewed in Week 2.
- **Relevant** — it is Submission 3 (7% of the grade) and the base for the Week 5 MVP.
- **Time-bound** — October 15, 2026, 23:59 (soft), October 16, 2026, 23:59 (hard).

Quiz

Why write SMART goals?

Threshold of success (ToS)

Discussion questions

What is success?

What is failure?

What is between them?

Why need threshold of success (ToS)?

Threshold of success (ToS):

- Helps focus on essential goals
- Increases chances for a clear project success
- Helps communicate goals to stakeholders
- Helps identify the most important risks that are necessary to manage

Guess the sequence of ToS steps

- Convert to success statements (how to avoid failure?)
- List failure statements (when can the project fail?)
- Gather the team
- Write a minimal set of SMART goals
- Build a minimum picture of failure

The sequence of ToS steps

1. Gather the team
2. Build a minimum picture of failure
3. List failure statements
4. Convert to success statements
5. Write a minimal set of SMART goals

Discussion questions

What can be a failure statement for your team?

Planning

Discussion questions

What is planning?

Why do people plan?

When do people plan?

What types of planning do you know?

Planning types

Strategic

- Long-term
- Achieve global project goals
- Keep in mind the threshold of success

Tactical

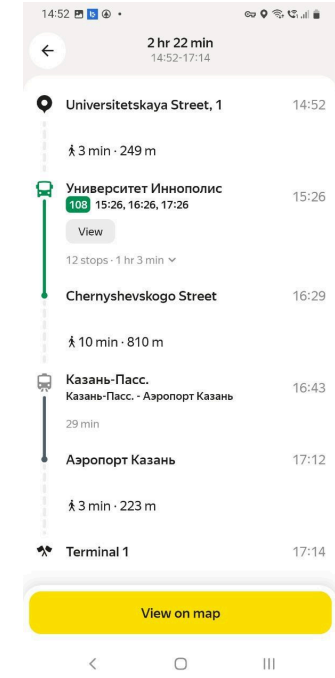
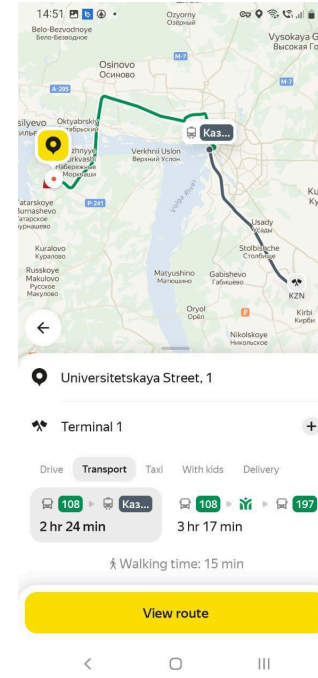
- Short-term
- Achieve local project goals
- Complete tasks
- Situational

Strategic planning

Strategic plan example

A navigation app provides a strategic plan

- a path from start to finish.



Strategic planning & tracking

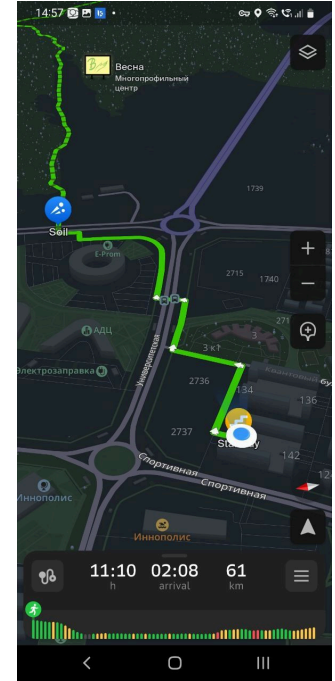
Level: project goals

- **Define success wrt. your goals**
 - Make it testable
 - Make sure all stakeholders agree (80% of pain comes from skipping this step)
- **Develop a roadmap**
 - Decompose the path to success into steps (sub-goals, milestones)
 - Find a “zoom level” that works for your project
- **Monitor progress - “tracking”**
 - Where are we in the project right now?
 - How much was done?
 - How much more do we have to do?
 - Are we on track to complete promised deliverables?
 - Can stakeholders clearly see our progress?
- **Make contingency plans**
 - Identify risks
 - Define alternative solutions
 - Identify “point of no return” decisions

Tactical planning

Tactical planning example

The same navigation app provides a tactical plan
- a step-by-step path to a local goal (sub-goal)



Tactical planning

Level: local sub-goals and tasks

- **Define who is responsible**
 - Every task has a specific person responsible for completing it (“responsible”)
- **Define when the work is done**
 - There is a Definition of Done for a task
 - There is a separate person who verifies that a task was done (“accountable”)
- **Review completed work**
 - Iteration demo
 - What went wrong?
 - What went right?
- **Adjust to fix discovered problems**
 - What should we keep from what went right?
 - Which steps should we take to improve iterations?

Quiz

What is strategic planning?

What is tactical planning?

What will happen if we ignore strategic planning?

What will happen if we lack tactical planning?

Questions?